

intrigues in the country, observers are quick to add that there's many a slip between the cup and the lip.

The foremost question relates to President Musharraf. His impeachment is improbable—a two-thirds majority in both the Senate and National Assembly is required for any impeachment motion to succeed and pro-Musharraf parties still hold a majority in the Senate. But most political pundits do not see much of a future for him given the overwhelming strength of his opponents in the new Assembly. If the pre-November judiciary is indeed restored as promised, most expect it to declare illegal Musharraf's re-election as President last September. Understandably, Musharraf has vowed time and again that the restoration of judges would not be allowed.

Questions also remain about how a restored judiciary would deal with the National Reconciliation Ordinance, which had been challenged in Pakistan's Supreme Court before November 3 and from which Zardari has benefited immensely as corruption cases against him were dropped. Legal complexities about the fate of the current judges—both those who continued under Musharraf's latest Provisional Constitution

the party's Senior Vice-President Makhdoom Amin Fahim, who Zardari himself had announced as the party's probable nominee after Benazir Bhutto's assassination. With speculation rife about other contenders for the top slot—foremost being Punjabi industrialist Chaudhry Ahmed Mukhtar—rumours have also gained ground that Zardari may be positioning to become prime minister himself.

According to those close to Zardari, since he is currently not a member of

THE HEAT IS ON: The new coalition has put Musharraf's future in doubt



AP PHOTO/YVES LOGGHE

elected legislators for him to assume the premiership himself. Increasingly, the delay in the announcement of PPP's candidate for the post is being seen as an attempt by Zardari to stage manage the nomination.

The internal PPP fissure is also threatening to spill over and impact the future coalition's relationship. PML(N) leader Khawaja Asif—who is also close to Zardari—claimed on television that PML(N) had, in effect, vetoed Fahim's nomination because of reservations about him and his closeness to Musharraf. Says Asif, "We feared he would become Musharraf's proxy." While PML(N) has sought to downplay Asif's comments as "not reflecting the official party thinking", Fahim has termed the accusations "the worst form of character assassination".

PPP leaders have tried to downplay talk of rifts but well-placed sources claim Asif's statement is proof of Zardari's use of the PML(N) platform to cut his rival down as his own party leaders were unwilling to speak against Fahim. It is also clear that if Zardari chooses to take centre stage in parliament himself, it may not be a unanimously popular decision.

Sources in PPP also confirm that the US is exerting pressure on Zardari to abandon his

THE MOVE TO IMPEACH PRESIDENT MUSHARRAF IS NOT EASY AS THE US IS OPPOSED TO IT.

Order (PCO) and newly-appointed ones—also abound. Some have also pointed out that even the sacked judges are not completely untarnished, since most of them, including sacked Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry, had taken oath under and legitimised General Musharraf's first PCO, enacted after the coup of 1999. So far, all attempts to mediate a solution to the issue of the judiciary have proved unsuccessful.

There is also now a growing rift within PPP over the question of prime ministership. The rift has been fuelled by Zardari's attempts to delay any announcement of the party's candidate for the prime ministerial post—seen by many as an attempt to sideline

parliament, he might need someone to be a transitional prime minister, at least until he can get elected. Fahim may be too senior a leader, and unwilling, to play this role. There is also the small matter of Zardari's graduation. Under rules framed by Musharraf in 2002, parliamentarians must possess a graduation degree, which sources claim Zardari does not have. If that is the case, he would need to have the new parliament overturn this clause before he can run for elections. Although this belies Bhutto's widower's statements that he would like to be Pakistan's Sonia Gandhi and forego the post of prime minister, rumours of Zardari's ambitions have received a boost with reports of calls from PPP's

apparent support for the restoration of the pre-November 3 judiciary. They are also not ready to abandon Musharraf completely, especially in the face of rising threats to Pakistan's security from pro-Taliban militants linked to Al Qaeda. The twin suicide bombings in Lahore on March 11 that targeted Pakistani counter-intelligence institutions—the city's fourth suicide bombing in two months—have only served to further alarm the US. Americans fear that the new democratic government may be too soft in executing the war against "Islamic militancy" and is particularly wary of PML(N)'s closeness to the religious lobby. The next few weeks will be a test for Pakistan's return to democracy. ■